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Youth and the Social Contract

Introduction

I feel that generally people in Pakistan do not believe citizenship exists. ... If it does, it is a luxury open only to the elite and for them citizenship is only rights and not duties or responsibilities. As a concept it does not matter to the majority where basic human needs are not being met.

(Teacher, Female, Karachi)

Thar mei bachei mar rahei hain unkei liyei kuchh nahi karna par cricket match peh cheezei jilaani hain.[1] *… We are willing to protest for not getting laptops but we won't do the same for the famine in Thar.*

(Focus Group, Government University[2])

These two observations, by a teacher in Karachi and an undergraduate student in Lahore, illustrate the fragmented nature of the social contract in Pakistan. Many postcolonial societies like Pakistan adopted a Western model of state–citizen relationship after independence. The social contract was almost a given for these newly independent countries in the advent of new state and institution building. After the Second World War, the decolonizing states were following in the democratic footsteps of their former Western colonial masters. As such the state was responsible for structural inputs – electricity, water and infrastructure – and services such as health and education as well as security, guaranteeing their citizens certain basic rights. Pakistan set up a state based on the social contract model, developing basic education, health and other public infrastructure for its citizens. From the start, however, Pakistan allowed for a parallel system to operate in the private sector, benefiting the richer sections of society. The poor, comprising the vast majority of the country, were reliant on the state to meet their basic needs. The response of the teacher from Karachi